Parshas Chayei Sarah

Carrying the Light Beyond Shabbos

A Life Completed · The Candles That Did Not Go Out · Two Flames and One · Growing Beyond Where We Begin

I. A Life Completed, a Mission That Continues

Parshas Chayei Sarah, the parsha that bears Sarah's name and speaks of the years of her life, opens with her passing. It follows directly upon the Akeidah at the end of last week's parsha, and Rashi, citing the Midrash, draws the two together. When the Satan brought Sarah word that her son had been taken up to be slaughtered, and she believed that Yitzchak was gone, the shock of it took her life. Of course Yitzchak was alive and well, and nothing had in truth befallen him. But Sarah, in that moment, lived through the loss of everything she had given her life to build.

There is another way to look at her passing as well, and it is one I shared with some people last year. Chazal describe the way a malach is sent into the world with a single tafkid, one mission to accomplish, and when that mission is complete the malach has fulfilled the purpose for which it was sent. Sarah stood on an extraordinarily elevated level, a malka, a queen, bound up with the concept of the Merkavah, a person so given over to Hashem that she carried His ratzon into the world. Perhaps her avodah, too, had reached its completion. Perhaps she had finished the work she was sent here to do, the building of the foundations of a nation, and from that fullness her neshamah departed. This does not lessen the loss. It reveals the completeness of a life wholly devoted to Hashem.

And yet, even when one person's avodah is complete, the larger mission goes on, and it runs straight into a truth set down at the very beginning of creation:

לא טוב היות האדם לבדו

"It is not good for man to be alone."
— Bereishis 2:18

A human being was never meant to exist entirely on his own. We are made to be together, to be bound to one another, to be part of something larger than ourselves, whether a marriage, a family, or a kehillah. Sarah, the wife to whom Avraham was bound and the mother to whom Yitzchak was bound, is no longer there, and Avraham understands the reality before him. A man should not be alone, and a son on the level to which Yitzchak had been raised needs a partner with whom to carry the mission forward. For Yitzchak had been elevated through the Akeidah. He had been offered to Hashem as an olah, and though he was neither slaughtered nor consumed upon the mizbeach, he remained from that moment on a pure and holy level. The one who would join him had to be able to rise to it. And so Avraham sends his servant Eliezer to his own family and his own people to seek a wife for his son.

II. The Servant Who Set Himself Aside

The Torah lingers at length on Eliezer's journey, and the care it takes is itself a teaching. Eliezer was a good man, a servant entrusted with great responsibility, and yet Chazal reveal

that he was not without interests of his own. Rashi explains that Eliezer had a daughter, and that he harbored a quiet hope that if no fitting woman could be found, perhaps his own daughter might marry Yitzchak. He came, moreover, from a background that Avraham did not consider fitting for his son. Avraham had been explicit: the wife was to come from his family, and Eliezer was bound to that charge. What makes Eliezer great is that he carried it out faithfully, setting his own hopes aside to serve the mission entrusted to him.

The journey itself was extraordinary. Chazal explain that Hashem performed for him a neis of kefitzas haderech, folding the road beneath him so that he reached Aram Naharayim on the very day he set out. And when he arrives, Eliezer does not make it easy, at least on the surface, for the right woman to be revealed. He turns to Hashem and sets out the sign by which he will know her. We can read his conditions in two ways. Perhaps he set so demanding and far-fetched a test because he was hoping to beat the system, so that no woman would qualify and his own daughter might yet be considered. Or perhaps Eliezer was so yashar, so deeply steeped in the values of Avraham's home, that he knew with precision what the wife of Yitzchak would have to be. For the sign he asks for is not a sign of beauty or of lineage. It is a sign of chesed.

III. A Woman Who Gives Beyond Herself

The young woman, Eliezer asks, must be willing to give him water when he asks, and then, of her own accord, to offer water to his camels as well. And not a little water, but enough for all of them, drawn and carried again and again. He is looking for someone who will not merely answer the need in front of her, but will see past it to a need unspoken, and give of herself far beyond what was asked. He is looking, in other words, for a woman built as Sarah was built.

And then Rivka arrives. Rashi explains that as she approached the well, the water rose up toward her, and a sequence of nissim and simanim unfolds, each one a sign that something momentous is taking place. We could linger a long while on Rivka's family and all that Eliezer encountered there, but the heart of it comes later, when she is asked whether she is willing to leave her home and travel to a land she has never seen to marry a man she has never met. Her answer is a single word:

אלך

"I will go."
— Bereishis 24:58

Rivka is prepared to step beyond the whole world she knows, to leave everything familiar behind, and to take up a purpose far greater than herself. It is through that willingness to give, and to go, that she becomes the next of the Imahos.

IV. The Candles That Did Not Go Out

Eliezer brings Rivka back, and she enters the tent of Sarah Imenu, and something remarkable happens. The brachos that had rested upon Sarah's tent throughout her lifetime, and had ceased when she died, return the moment Rivka enters. Rashi, drawing on the Midrash, describes three of them, that a cloud of the Shechinah hung over the tent, that a blessing rested in the dough, and that a candle burned from Erev Shabbos to Erev Shabbos. When Sarah passed, all three ceased; when Rivka came, all three returned, and Yitzchak was comforted, for he saw in his wife the continuation of his mother.

It is the candle that we want to dwell on. Every Erev Shabbos, Sarah would kindle her light, and that single flame would burn on, unbroken, until the following Erev Shabbos. The candles we light ordinarily illuminate our homes for an evening. In Sarah's home, the light of one Shabbos reached all the way to the next. And this was no accident of a woman who happened to merit a miracle. It was the outward form of who Sarah was. We have seen across these parshiyos how much Sarah was willing to give and to sacrifice of herself, for her husband, for her family, and for all those around her. That giving nature, that endless willingness to bring light and good into the world, was Sarah Imenu, and when Rivka took up her mantle within the home, she took up that light as well.

V. The Light of Shalom Bayis

The Shabbos candle carries a meaning far beyond its flame. The Gemara teaches that the lighting of the Shabbos candles is bound up with shalom bayis, the peace of the home:

נר של שבת משום שלום ביתו

"The Shabbos candle is for the sake of the peace of one's home."
— Shabbos 23b

The light fills the home so that those within it can be together in comfort and in peace. And the Zohar, in Parshas Bereishis, takes us deeper still. It speaks of the Sukkas Shalom, the shelter of peace:

סוכת שלום

"The shelter of peace."
— based on the Zohar, Bereishis

The Zohar associates this Sukkas Shalom with the Matronita, an expression of the Shechinah, and teaches that when a woman kindles the Shabbos lights with joy and with proper intention, she draws that presence into her home. She is not merely putting a little light into a dark room. She is creating an environment of kedushah and of peace, a home in which something far greater can come to dwell. The Jewish home, lit by that flame, becomes more than a shelter of walls. It becomes a dwelling fit for the Shechinah.

VI. Adam and the First Flame

There is another encounter with candlelight that we come to every single week, and though it is not directly tied to our parsha, it opens the idea further. At the close of Shabbos, at Havdalah, we make a brachah over fire. Chazal teach that this commemorates the first fire, which Adam HaRishon was given the understanding to produce on the very first Motzaei Shabbos:

במוצאי שבת נתן הקדוש ברוך הוא דעה באדם הראשון והביא שני אבנים וטחנן זו בזו ויצא מהן אור

"On Motzaei Shabbos, HaKadosh Baruch Hu placed understanding in Adam HaRishon, and he brought two stones and rubbed them together, and fire came forth from them."
— Pesachim 54a

Consider the moment this fire is born into. Adam had eaten from the Eitz HaDaas Tov VaRa, what Rabbi Gerzi calls the tree-eating boo-boo experience, and that stumbling had come about through the relationship between Adam and Chava. On one side stands a great

fall, bound up with the bond between husband and wife. And yet, on the other side of that same Shabbos, Adam is given the understanding to bring forth fire. He does not create the stones, nor the hidden potential within them, nor the laws by which they yield a spark; all of that is Hashem's. But he is given the knowledge to take what Hashem has made and draw something new out of it. He is no longer only a shomer in the Gan, a keeper of what already is. He becomes a shutaf with Hashem, a partner in the ongoing development of creation, able to work, to build, and to bring new things into the world.

And perhaps that is itself a lesson about the bond between husband and wife. There can be stumbling, and there can be things that do not unfold as they should. But in the very same relationship lies the capacity to grow, to build, to seek the tov, and to bring greater good into the world than either one could bring alone. The fall and the fire belong to the same story, and it is the fire, the building, that has the last word.

VII. Two Flames and One

Let us look a little more closely at the candles themselves. When we enter Shabbos, we kindle individual flames, each with its own wick, each burning on its own. We come into Shabbos seeking shalom bayis, the unity of the household, and yet we light separate lights, because within that unity each of us remains ourselves. Each person in the home has his own neshamah, her own strengths, a particular purpose and a particular gift to bring into the world, and Hashem is present among them all. Shalom bayis has never meant that our individuality dissolves. It means that each distinct light is brought willingly into one shared home. And within the kedushah of Shabbos this is, in a sense, the easier thing, for Shabbos carries its own kedushah; we are entering a time that Hashem has already sanctified, and it holds us upright of its own accord.

But at Havdalah something changes. Here the choicest way to make the brachah is over an avukah, a torch of several flames twisted together, as Chazal established (Shulchan Aruch, Orach Chaim 298:2). And here I would offer my own sevara, in the hope of one day finding it set down more explicitly in the sefarim. When we leave Shabbos and step down from kodesh into chol, from the sanctity of the day into the ordinary labor of the week, we no longer have the kedushah of Shabbos holding us up on its own. What do we have instead? We have those to whom we are bound, those with whom our lives are intertwined, the people who help us stand upright as we cross from holiness into the week. Perhaps that is what the braided wicks of the avukah are telling us. We are no longer looking at a single flame standing on its own. We are looking at many flames joined into one, together casting enough light to see the way ahead.

And it is not only husband and wife, nor only family. It is our bond with Hashem as well. As we enter the week, we have to draw upon the kedushah of Shabbos and carry it with us into the world, and for that we need both the people around us and the Ribbono Shel Olam beside us. The single flame of Shabbos becomes the braided flame of the week, because the week cannot be walked alone.

VIII. Carrying the Light Into the Week

Here we return to the miracle of Sarah's tent, and to Rivka who restored it. Their candles burned from Erev Shabbos to Erev Shabbos. They carried the light of one Shabbos through the whole of the week until the next, and that is precisely what we are meant to learn to do. Through the six days we prepare ourselves for Shabbos, and Shabbos in turn lifts us to a

height that gives us the koach to return to the six days. There is a cycle here, turning in both directions: the week readies us for Shabbos, and Shabbos gives us the strength to carry back into the week. To keep that light burning once the candles have gone out is itself part of our partnership with Hashem.

For we are meant to bring Hashem with us into this world, to draw upon His kedushah in order to stand upright, to place one foot in front of the other, and to keep moving forward. And we are meant to lean, as well, on the people around us. Hashem is always there, nearer than we know. And yet it was Hashem Himself who said that it is not good for man to be alone. We need unity. We need connection. We need that binding of one life to another. The Akeidah shows us a person willing to give up everything for Hashem, and that is a towering height. But there is another giving, quieter and daily, that we are also asked for, the willingness to give of ourselves for the person in front of us, the one we see every single day: our spouse, our family, the people who stand at our side.

IX. Growing Beyond Where We Begin

There is a further lesson running beneath all of this. Rivka did not come from a household of tzaddikim. Chazal describe the home she left as a place of deceit and corruption, a place where even the servant who came to arrange her marriage was in danger. And later, Rachel and Leah will come from that same broader family. Yet these are the women who become the Imahos, who rise above the world that raised them and build homes of extraordinary kedushah. There is a tremendous lesson in that, about how far a person can grow beyond the circumstances into which they were born.

We can see it, too, in the way the middos of the Avos and Imahos complement one another. Avraham is the pillar of chesed, and Sarah brings a strength that completes him, a measure of gevurah, of restraint and boundary; she is described as tzanua, one who knows how to hold herself back and bring balance into the home. Yitzchak is gevurah, precision and restraint and an unbending commitment to his avodah, and Rivka answers him with a different energy altogether. Her chesed overflows at the well, pouring out for a stranger and his camels, and she carries with it initiative, courage, and the will to act; later, when the twins struggle within her, she goes out to seek understanding of what is happening to her. We might call it a kind of chutzpah of chesed, the boldness to push forward because one genuinely wants good for another. And from the meeting of these middos, through barrenness and tefillah and relationships asked to bear enormous weight, the house is built, until we reach Yaakov, who is tiferes, the balance and integration of chesed and gevurah, in whose complex household the family that will become Klal Yisrael finally takes shape.

But the thread that ties all of them together, Eliezer included, is the willingness to go beyond oneself. Eliezer was no Av; he was a servant, and he had hopes of his own. Yet at the decisive moment he set them aside and carried out the mission he was given. Each of these figures, in his or her own way and at a different stage, was able to say: I can be more than my own wants and desires, more than the reality immediately around me. I can give of myself. I can give up even my own plans, because I understand that Hashem asks something more of me today. Rivka could have been seen as simply escaping a hard home, but the truth is harder and greater than that, for it was still her home, her family, the only world she had ever known, and she was willing to leave all of it behind and walk into the unknown because something greater was waiting. And Sarah, the first of the Imahos, had shown that same willingness across her entire life, giving of herself for Avraham and for the future of their family, willing even to bring Hagar into her home for the sake of what needed to be built. These are the people the Torah holds up as our examples and our guides.

So how do we become meshutafim with HaKadosh Baruch Hu, true partners with Hashem? We act with tznius and with yashrus. We look for the kadosh in the things around us. We ask ourselves how we can grow, how we can lift up our families, how we can bring more goodness into our olam. And we learn to look beyond the environment in which we find ourselves, however small or limited the place we are starting from, and to keep growing until we begin to recognize the true depth of what we are capable of. From there we become part of something far greater than ourselves, building not only our own lives, but our families, our communities, and in time the nation we are meant to become.

May this be a Shabbos on which we reflect on how to become the truest version of ourselves, how to grow, and how to do teshuvah. May we have the courage of Rivka to step beyond the world we know, and may we learn to carry the light of Shabbos with us, together with Hashem and with those around us, into the building and the elevating of this world.

חזק ואחזק

Good Shabbos.

Reflection Questions

- *Where in my life am I trying to stand entirely on my own, when the truth set down at creation is that it is not good for a person to be alone?*
- *Who are the intertwined flames beside me, my spouse, my family, my community, and am I letting them help me stand upright as I move from the kedushah of Shabbos into the week?*
- *Does the light of my Shabbos go out when the candles do, or do I carry its kedushah into the ordinary days that follow?*
- *What in my week am I actually building as a partner with Hashem, taking what He has created and developing it according to His ratzon?*
- *Like Eliezer and Rivka, where am I being asked to set aside my own plans or my own comfort because something greater is required of me today?*
- *Where am I letting the place I came from, or the limits I believe define me, decide who I can become, when Rivka rose from such a home to become an Imah?*